The Ferris Wheel

By Mary Miller

A woman is seated with her arms outstretched in front of her, her fists clenched, her feet planted firmly on the ground and her eyes shut. A man enters. He looks down at the woman, then behind him, then back at the woman. He starts to sit next to her.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Throughout our lives, we have chance encounters with people or situations that can be — and often are — life transforming.*
ACTOR: *Think back for a moment. How did you meet your spouse [significant other]?*
ACTRESS: *Sure, there are online matchmaking sites,*
ACTOR: *But most people meet the person of their dreams through a chance encounter —*
ACTRESS: *At a grocery store,*
ACTOR: *Or a dance class, or on . . .*
TOGETHER: *The Ferris Wheel by Mary Miller*

ONAL USE ONLY

JOHN: Excuse me. Excuse me? I hope I'm not . . . crowding you . . .

DORIE: *(flustered/embarrassed)* No. *(He slides into the empty seat next to her and takes hold of the "bar")*

JOHN: I would have taken another seat but the line is too long to let anyone ride by themselves *(She nods but doesn't respond)* . . . They force you to be a couple whether you want to or not . . . not that I mind. I mean it's a pleasure. *(He looks at her, sitting bolt upright and perfectly rigid)* Are you comfortable?

DORIE: Just fine (a jerk) Whoops . . . we're off. *(She squeezes her fists tighter, clenches her eyes shut and presses her feet to the floor)*

JOHN: Are you all right?

DORIE: Couuuuldn't be better.

JOHN: But you're not looking?

DORIE: No. Heights. I'm frightened of heights.

JOHN: And you ride a ferris wheel?

DORIE: Just once a year. On my birthday.

JOHN: Happy birthday. *(He looks at her gripping the bar)* Your knuckles are turning white. . . Are you sure this is good for your circulation?

DORIE: What doesn't kill me makes me stronger, type of thing.

JOHN: So you do this in lieu of a birthday part with cake and ice cream?

DORIE: Oh no, I have that too, when I get through. Like a reward. My Daddy started it and I keep it up.

JOHN: He was frightened of heights?

DORIE: Oh no, he just believed you should do something that frightens you at least once a year. Builds character. Strengthens moral fiber. You ought to try it sometime. I had this cousin once who tried to pretend like she was frightened of small places until she got locked in the attic during a thunderstorm. Lightning struck that house and burned it to the ground.

JOHN: Now she's frightened of fire?

DORIE: No sir, she's dead. You can't go messing with things like this.

JOHN: Truth is stranger than fiction.

DORIE: Don't you know it. Once I had this art teacher named Miss Thumb, who was missing two fingers. She used to say to paint all you needed were your ten good fingers and she'd hold up eight. *(She demonstrates and then grabs for the bar)* Whoooppppsss!!

JOHN: Are you all right?!

DORIE: I'm fine. *(pause)* . . . . You're not from around here?

JOHN: No. Passing through, saw the wheel and drove on over. That's my little red car down there. *(He points. She starts to look and stops)*

DORIE: I'll take your word for it. *(Suddenly they both jerk forward in their seats . . . and stop still).* Oh my God! What happened?

JOHN: Looks like we stopped. We seem to be stuck *(He leans forward to look)*

DORIE: Don't do that!! Don't move! You're rocking the car. Please don't rock the car.

JOHN: I'm sorry. They're probably just making an adjustment. We'll be moving . . . *(They do not move. He looks at her)* . . . any minute.

DORIE: Yes. *(panic growing)* We should be . . . rolling? Any . . . minute . . . ?!

JOHN: Would you care for a cigarette? Calm your nerves.

DORIE: Me? No. I don't smoke . . . *(motions for him to go ahead)* It doesn't bother me. *(He starts to light up)* When I was younger I saw this demonstration with an invisible man, where they hung this sack off his windpipe and said it was an exact duplicate of the human lung tissue. Then they put this lit cigarette in its plastic mouth and we watched the smoke slowly trickle down into the lung sack. And all of a sudden it started popping and bubbling – disintegrating right in front of our very eyes 'til it was nothing but a brown dripping glob hanging off that clear plastic windpipe. They said that's what happens to a tiny layer of your lung every time you take a puff. So I don't care to smoke myself, but if you want to, go right ahead. *(He looks at the cigarette in his hand, changing his mind).*

JOHN: I was thinking of giving it up. Now would be as good a time as any. Right? . . . Do something you're frightened of . . . sure? Why not?

DORIE: Once you do, it's best not to take it back. Remember my poor dead cousin . . .

JOHN: I don't need a cigarette

DORIE: Good. *(He pats his chest pocket where his cigarettes are, then starts twitching his shoulder, drumming his fingers on his leg impatiently . . . leans over, looks down.)*

JOHN: It must be mechanical

DORIE: *(newly panicked)* Mechanical?! We could be up here for days. *(he gives her a skeptical look)* It is possible.

JOHN: Anything is possible . . .

DORIE: Oh, God.

JOHN: Why don't you open your eyes?

DORIE: I'm frightened of heights! . . . So much for my luck. I should have checked my horoscope.

JOHN: We're going to be . . . all right *(referring to having quit smoking)* I'm going to be . . . OK? *(He looks away from his pocket and pats his chest)* This isn't so bad. *(Uneasily, he takes a deep breath)* So, how long has it been? *(He feels in his pants pockets)* You wouldn't happen to have any gum, would you? Juicy Fruit? . . . Doublemint?

DORIE: Gum? No . . . My grandmother never allowed it.

JOHN: Neither would mine.

DORIE: She thought it was tacky. Bad for your teeth.

JOHN: . . . a waste of money.

DORIE: . . . socially incorrect. So, I doubt I have any gum. But you're welcome to look.

JOHN: No. I can wait. *(pause)* So . . . Seriously. How long has it been?

DORIE: Five minutes.

JOHN: Just five minutes *(He unconsciously starts moving his leg and tapping his foot)*

DORIE: *(without looking down)* What are you doing?! You're moving.

JOHN: I'm not moving.

DORIE: You're twitching.

JOHN: Twitching?

DORIE: *(Pointing down / looking up)* Your leg. It's going like a house on fire. Are you nervous? . . . Or is this some sort of warning signal before you break into a full uncontrollable fit?

JOHN: I am not breaking into a fit! I'm not twitching! Look. *(She doesn't look)* Don't look. See . . . *(He holds his hand out in front of him)* . . . Steady as a rock. *(His hands start to shake, he grabs for the bar)* Oh, God.

DORIE: What if they make us climb out on a ladder?! *(panic)* I can't climb out on a ladder. I'm going to be sick.

JOHN: Just take a deep breath. It's mind over matter. Just breathe. Breathe. *(The both breathe together, she a deep breath and he like he's smoking an imaginary cigarette)* Better?

DORIE: Better.

JOHN: It's all will power. *(he closes his eyes)* Visualization. See a stream. A peaceful . . . quiet . . . winding stream . . . . *(Smiling)* . . . draw it into your mouth . . . taste it . . . feel it going down . . . hitting you here. *(He hits his chest and coughs violently – He opens his eyes, sits upright)* You wouldn't happen to have a Tic Tac . . . Lifesaver . . . cracker . . . ?

DORIE: I wish you'd quit mentioning food. That's like talking about going to the bathroom in a moving car riding down the highway.

JOHN: I hadn't though about the ***bathroom***. *(He crosses his legs)*

DORIE: Just promise me one thing. Promise me you won't eat me.

JOHN: Eat you?

DORIE: It happens. I've read about it. "Snowbound in the Andes." "Shipwrecked on a Desert Island." Two people stranded together and one eats the other. Instead of falling in love, you have to worry about being dinner.

JOHN: I am not that hungry.

DORIE; Of course, I could stand to lose a pound or two . . . but I never los it where it counts – it drops out of my face and I look like a cadaver with hops.

JOHN: I feel fat. Do I look fat? I am putting on weight and I'm just sitting here!

DORIE: Nonsense. You're thin.

BOTH: I used to be thin.

DORIE: *(During the following John starts picking lint off his jacket and biting his finger nails)* In high school, I was so thin when I wore panty hose I pinned them to my bra. That kept my panty hose up and my bra down.

JOHN: But you filled out nicely.

DORIE: *(embarrassed)* Thank you.

JOHN: *(distracted)* A regular beauty pageant contestant.

DORIE: I was once. But I didn't win.

JOHN: The prettiest girl doesn't always win. *(He bites at a nail)*

DORIE: Of course not. If looks were all that counted, ***anybody*** could win.

JOHN: I bet you won Miss Congeniality. Anybody as . . . ah . . . as . . ***chatty*** . . .as you would have won Miss Congeniality. (He spits out a nail)

DORIE: That's just my breeding. My mother always said it was our social obligation to be entertaining.

JOHN: Don't have to feel any obligation on my account

DORIE: No! You're easy to talk to. I could talk to you all day.

JOHN: *(reacting, he bites his finger)* Ouch!

DORIE: You are going to bite those nails clear down to the nub if you're not careful.

JOHN: It's just a . . . hangnail.

DORIE: I had this roommate in school once who got gangrene from an infected hangnail. Nearly had to have her finger cut off. . .

JOHN: *(takes his hand out of his mouth, starts feeling for his cigarettes) (recalling)* You said, that cousin of yours – who broke this pact . . . Died, didn't she?

DORIE: Deader than a door nail. They say that poor little body was charred beyond . . .

JOHN: STOP! I'll pay you a hundred dollars if you don't say another work.

DORIE: I could never take money from a stranger. My mother always told me . . .

JOHN: *(Interrupting/loosening his tie)* Is it hot up here? Do you feel hot? I feel hot . . .

DORIE: No.

JOHN: How can you feel anything? You haven't stopped talking since we sat down. I'm sorry. It's my fault. *(pause)* Five minutes?! It's only been five minutes! They say when you die your life flashes in front of you in five minutes. I never believed that was possible before now.

DORIE: I'm sorry. I'm boring you.

JOHN: You're not boring me. It's just . . . *(He pats chest)* I've been smoking ever since I was twelve. They'd give me a dollar for the collection plate at church and I'd fish out change – enough for a pack. God got the bulk of it, but He's getting even now.

DORIE: No, you are right. I do talk too much. I always have. Especially when I'm nervous . . . or scared. Sometimes I get so wound up I can feel myself floating up over my body and I just want to slap myself silly saying . . . "Shut up. Shut up. Shut up." *(pause)* Like now. I'm sorry.

JOHN: It's OK.

DORIE: No, you see my greatest flaw is . . I just want people to like me. I'm about the only person I know who thought Sally Field's acceptance speech at the Academy Awards . . "You Like me! You like me!" . . . had real depth. I understood what she meant. But sometimes what we do has the exact opposite results.

JOHN: I like you.

DORIE: How can you tell, you keep twitching and biting and picking . . .

JOHN: . . . and listening Sometimes when I listen to you I forget about smoking. I do . . like you . . and . ah . . I don't even know your name.

DORIE: My name is . . . Dorien. But people call me Dorie.

JOHN: Pleased to meet you . . . Dorie. I'm John. *(He holds out his hand to shake hers and as she does, she briefly looks down and regrabs the bar.)*

DORIE: I'm sorry about the smoking. But I bet your wife will be happy.

JOHN: I'm not married. You?

DORIE: *(embarrassed)* Me?! No!

JOHN: Divorced. Traveling salesman . . . only she couldn't take the traveling so she moved on. You get used to being alone. You get over it. You adjust.

DORIE: Isn't that the truth. Why, I don't even mind eating by myself anymore. Not as long as I have something to reed. Newspaper, magazine, those little bitty sugar packets they set at the table, the ones with the history of each state written real tiny on the back. You can learn a lot eating alone. The state flowers. The state birds . . . *(John suddenly leans over and kisses her on the cheek)* What did you do that for?

JOHN: I don't know . . . I thought if I kissed you, you'd stop talking for a minute. *(She looks at him. He leans over an kisses her on the lips)*

DORIE: *(nervous/flustered/she starts talking again)* Did I tell you I have an aunt who lives in Dublin, Georgia; semi-related to Kim Basinger? You remember the movie The Nautral . . . Well, she was in it . . . Kim . . not my aunt . . . and when they started *(John leans over and kisses her again on the lips) (Suddenly they both jerk back in their seats)*

DORIE: What was that?!

JOHN: Looks like we're moving. Won't be long now. *(looking)* They're letting us out one by one. *(They jerk again in their seats)* This is us. *(They both raise their arms up and let go of the "bar) (Dorrie jumps out, extends her hand in a formal good bye)*

DORIE: It . . . it . . has been a pleasure. *(John takes her hand)* Well. . . you better get going . . . and have that cigarette. I wouldn't want you to get in any trouble kissing every girl in the park just so you can make it through the day without smoking . . . I better get going. *(She lets go of his hand and starts to walk away)*

JOHN: *(hollering out to her)* Dorie, you coming back next year?

DORIE: It is a tradition. And you know, my family, we're keen on tradition.

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